

The Kalahari Desert

Not a true desert but a massive sandy savanna with adequate rainfall and a covering of vegetation in parts, yet no water on the surface or in the soil



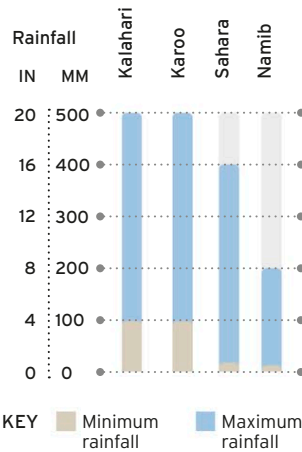
Despite summer temperatures that top 104°F (40°C) and seemingly endless sand sheets, the Kalahari is not, technically, a desert. Parts of this semiarid region, which covers most of Botswana and some of Namibia and South Africa, receive more rainfall annually than the 10 in (250 mm) that is traditionally used to classify desert areas. While rainfall in the Kalahari’s southwestern half falls within this range, the northeast gets almost double that figure—yet no surface water remains here. Any rain

drains immediately through the deep sands, creating a soil completely devoid of moisture. Despite this and the huge dune-chains that characterize its western half, the Kalahari contains considerable plant life. Deep-rooted acacia trees, shrubs, and some grasses grow in the center, while the north boasts forested areas. More animals are found in the north, but in the arid south, grazing species such as kudu and gemsbok track down enough vegetation to survive.



RAINFALL

Total rainfall is only one factor in classifying deserts. Although the Kalahari and Karoo receive over twice the precipitation of true deserts, their rainfall is seasonal, which means that there may be no rain in some areas for 6-8 months.



◀ RUST RED
A herd of gemsbok stands out against the red Kalahari sand, which gets its intense color from iron oxide.

The Karoo

A semiarid cape zone, containing many of the world’s succulent plant species



Covering about a third of South Africa, the Karoo is one of the driest regions of the country. Noted for its vast open spaces interspersed with Karoo koppies (flat-topped hills), rugged mountains, and fossil deposits, this desert also contains a fertile zone along the coast that is home to one-third of the world’s succulent plant species. In the west, spring rains transform the landscape, covering it with carpets of vivid orange and pink flowers. The region is divided into sub-Karoos—the more desertlike Upper Karoo, the lower-lying plateau basin called the Great (Groot) Karoo, and the relatively fertile Little (Klein) Karoo.

▷ BRANCHING SUCCULENT
The quiver tree is a tree-sized succulent, with a stem that grows to a diameter of 3 ft (1 m). Desert bushmen hollow out its tubular branches to make quivers for arrows, giving it its name.

